

Varun *nahin aandhi hai, doosra* Sanjay Gandhi *hai*,” said his supporters outside Pilibhit jail as their new found saviour, clad in a red kurta and sporting vermilion on his forehead, repeatedly gestured in the air. For someone who has lived in the shadow of his father's lost legacy, the longed for comparison must not have been lost. Especially with BJP's prime minister-in-waiting Lal Krishna Advani's shocking endorsement a day later, comparing him to Sanjay and Indira Gandhi's *bete noire*, Jayaprakash Narayan. By detaining Varun under the National Security Act (NSA), Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Mayawati achieved the impossible: she transformed Varun, whose inflammatory statements about Muslims in election rallies in Pilibhit had initially stunned even the BJP into confused silence, into a Hindutva pin-up. By saying in Bhubaneswar that Varun's detention reminded him of the arrest of “great patriots like Jayaprakash Narayan, Morarji Desai and Atal Bihari Vajpayee” who were imprisoned under the Maintenance of Internal Security Act, Advani immediately sanctified Varun's vicious gambit, to use the politics of hate to get what he has always longed for, national prominence. The irony of the situation was clearly lost on Advani—that he was praising the son of the man who had instigated the Emergency in the country.

For Mayawati, under attack from both the Congress and the Samajwadi Party for allowing Varun to lead a huge procession through the busy roads of Pilibhit despite Section 144 of the IPC, slapping the NSA on him was an opportunity to answer her critics who felt she had allowed the 29-year-old monster-in-the-making to hog television coverage. By invoking the NSA for the first time since the Emergency against a candidate, she displayed her decisiveness to handle her adversaries—she had earlier prevented Advani from addressing a public rally in the state. By acting tough against the BJP leaders she was sending a strong signal to the Muslims in the state who have the power to influence the electoral outcome in 20 crucial Lok Sabha sets. She

also sent a shiver down the spine of her chief political opponent in Uttar Pradesh, Samajwadi Party chief Mulayam Singh Yadav, who staged a surprising defence of Varun, saying he was not “anti-national” and that slapping the NSA on him was an injustice. He was clearly worried that an emboldened Mayawati would use the NSA against his workers. As for the Congress, it was sent scurrying into a defensive mode, with Prime Minister Manmohan Singh saying the Centre had nothing to do with the NSA.

For Varun, who has sought Supreme Court relief, as well as an upgrade of security in view of the greater “threat perception”, the acceptance by the BJP must be a sweet victory. Whether in jail or out of it, he has got the support

of the entire Sangh Parivar and an equal if not higher national profile than his cousin. Both the mother, who is fighting from neighbouring Aonla, after winning six times from Pilibhit, and the son will get a place of prominence in the party if they manage to win. The BJP has already adopted him as a victim of vendetta even as it maintains that he never made the questionable parts of the speech. It needed an icon to revive the party in Uttar Pradesh and will exploit Varun's newly-discovered extremist appeal. To top it all, as Varun's supporters who fought an eight-hour-long battle with the police on the day he courted arrest, showed, he can inspire street fights. Ironically, though, after the initial euphoria when Pramod Mahajan in-

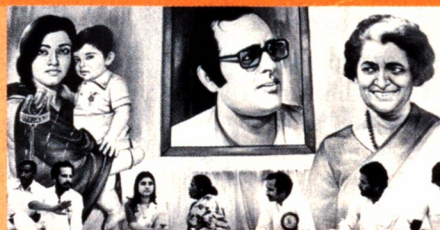
ducted him into the party in 2004, Varun has been struggling to gain acceptance, especially with the RSS, attending functions by the side of the then Sangh supremo K.S. Sudarshan, and penning hawkish articles on national security in the *Organiser*. His abiding self-confidence and inborn desire for leadership have been seen as misplaced arrogance and in 2006, he was denied the Lok Sabha ticket from Vidisha during the by-elections.

Being Feroze Varun Gandhi, sometime messiah of hate and sometime sensitive, if unintelligible, poet, must not be easy. Consumed by anger at having been denied his rightful inheritance, and yet unable to create his own personal

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1982 Feroze Varun with Indira Gandhi on his father's death anniversary. Maneka alleges that Sanjay's death anniversary is being turned into a day of farcical tamashas and show of strength by the Congress party and declares it a Vidhwa Diwas (widows' day).



1983 Maneka forms a political party, the Rashtriya Sanjay Manch, named after her husband. In 1988, she joins the Janata Dal.

2004 Feroze Varun joins the BJP along with his mother. In 2009, the party fields Varun from Pilibhit in Uttar Pradesh after Maneka vacates the constituency from where she was elected to the Lok Sabha six times.